

# Making Strangers Familiar: Pet-Mediated Interaction in Organized Pet Group Tours

## ABSTRACT

Existing research on pet-inclusive tourism has mainly examined travel motivations, mobility constraints, and pet-friendly service provision, leaving less understood how companion animals shape social relations among strangers during travel. This study examines organized pet group tours in China as multispecies settings in which pets mediate tourist-to-tourist interaction and shape temporary travel ties.

Drawing on 21 semi-structured interviews with Chinese pet owners, the study interprets the data through interaction ritual chains and neo-tribe theory. The findings show that pets reorganize the interactional order of group travel in consequential ways. Transport restrictions, accommodation uncertainty, and repeated access negotiations push owners into organized formats. Once assembled, pets become recurring interactional foci: their sniffing, playing, anxiety, and care needs often precede owner-to-owner communication, creating low-pressure openings around breed, temperament, health, and everyday care. Crucially, pet-first interaction is not automatically positive; reactive or anxious animals can equally produce avoidance.

Where interaction occurred, shared care practices, including holding leashes, watching pets, sharing supplies, and managing frictions, generated care-grounded familiarity: situational closeness built through collective responsibility for animal well-being rather than personal disclosure. Post-tour ties remained uneven, shaped by geographical proximity, overlapping routines, and pet compatibility. The study shows that multispecies co-presence does not simply add animals to group tour sociality; it reorganizes the interactional process through which strangers become, temporarily, something more.

**Keywords:** pet tourism; pet-mediated interaction; interaction ritual chains; neo-tribe theory; care-grounded familiarity